

SEFER YONAH 1:1-3

Why did Yonah *run?*

Sforno's answer

JONAH • Yael • JACOB



Rabbi Ovadiah Sforno

Born around 1470

Died around 1550

Lived in Italy

- He was a doctor.
- He taught Hebrew to a Christian scholar named Johannes Reuchlin.
- He ran a beit midrash in Bologna until he died.
- He wrote a philosophy book called Or Ammim.

How he reads Tanach

- He goes with the simple meaning of the words.
- He looks closely at the exact word the pasuk uses.
- He asks what it teaches us about people.

✓ PSHAT

✓ EXACT WORDS

✓ PHILOSOPHY

✗ KABBALAH



A page of Mikraot Gedolot printed in Venice in 1525

וַיִּקָּם יוֹנָה לְבָרַח תַּרְשִׁישָׁה מִלְּפָנֵי ה' וַיֵּרֶד
יָפוֹ וַיִּמְצֵא אֲנִיָּה בָאָה תַרְשִׁישׁ

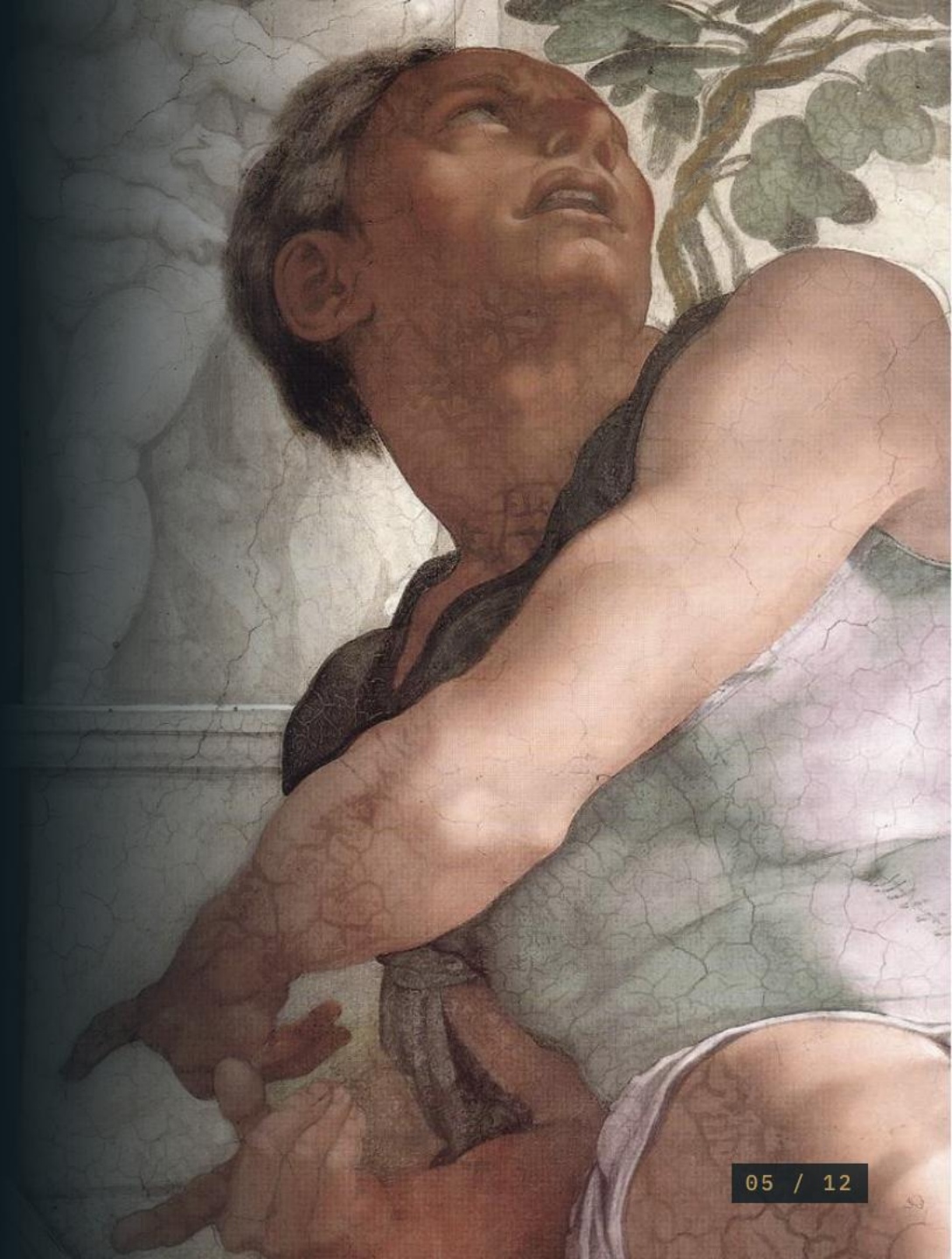
"But Jonah rose up to flee unto Tarshish from the presence of the LORD; and he went down to Joppa, and found a ship going to Tarshish"

JPS 1917

Hashem is everywhere.

So how can a prophet run away from Him?

This is the big question Sforno asks about our pasuk.



Hebrew has two words for running away

בְּרִיחָה

BRICHA

You leave a place because something bad is there.



נִיסָה

NISA

You run from something that is chasing you.



The pasuk uses the word לְבַרְחָה. So Yonah was leaving a place. He knew he could not outrun Hashem.

Yonah left Eretz Yisrael

Prophecy comes in Eretz Yisrael. Yonah thought that if he left the Land the message about Nineveh would stop coming to him.



Hashem sent him east. He sailed west.

Why didn't he want to go?

*"for I knew that Thou art a gracious God, and
compassionate, long-suffering, and abundant in
mercy, and repentest Thee of the evil."*

YONAH 4:2 JPS 1917

Yonah knew Nineveh would do teshuva. He knew Hashem would forgive them.

Why Hashem kept Yonah

1:4 A big storm hits the ship

2:1 A big fish swallows Yonah

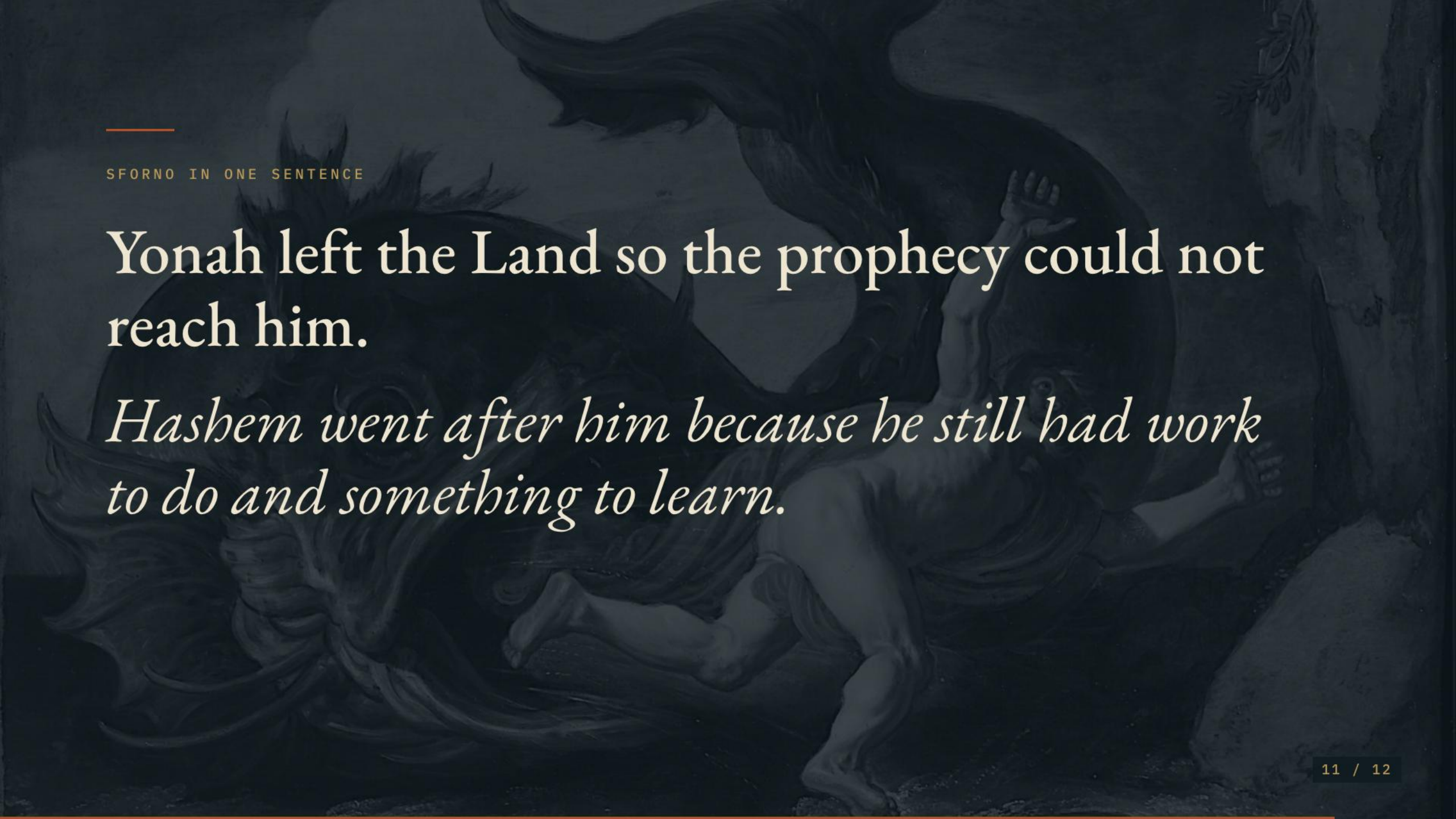
3:1 Hashem sends him a second time

Yonah still believed in Hashem. He made a mistake and Hashem gave him a chance to fix it. Hashem also wanted to teach him about mercy. That is what chapter 4 is about.



A student gets picked to give a speech he does not agree with.
He stays home sick so no one can give it to him.
The principal calls his house anyway.

*That is Yonah. He left the place where the job was given. The
job still found him.*



SFORNO IN ONE SENTENCE

Yonah left the Land so the prophecy could not reach him.

Hashem went after him because he still had work to do and something to learn.

SOURCES

Where this came from

TEXTS

Sefer Yonah 1:3 and 1:4 and 2:1 and 3:1 and 4:2. Hebrew text and English translation from *The Holy Scriptures* (Jewish Publication Society 1917) on Sefaria.org

Sforno on Yonah 1:3 as summarized in "Yonah Perek Aleph" on Otzar HaMikra (otzar.org.il)

ABOUT SFORNO

"Sforno, Obadiah ben Jacob." *Encyclopaedia Judaica* (2nd ed. 2007) on Jewish Virtual Library

"Obadiah ben Jacob Sforno." Wikipedia

FONTS

EB Garamond, Frank Ruhl Libre and IBM Plex Mono from Google Fonts

IMAGES (WIKIMEDIA COMMONS)

Pieter Lastman. *Jonah and the Whale*. 1621. Museum Kunstpalast Düsseldorf. Public domain

Michelangelo. *Jonah*. Sistine Chapel ceiling. 1512. Public domain

Gustave Doré. *Jonah Preaches to the Ninevites* and *Jonah Is Spewed Forth by the Whale*. 1866. Public domain

Joan Blaeu. Map of Bologna. 17th century. Public domain

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